

CONCEPT · TIM KING & CLAUDE · SEPTEMBER 2026

Work Pattern Color Standard

A validated, colorblind-safe color mapping for the five HITL work patterns — Decision, Knowledge, Document, Transaction, Exception

DocumentationDashboardWork in Progress

Concept stage — not yet part of the framework. Directly operationalizes Rule 2 (One Pattern Legend) of the unified Framework Content Generation Rules: one fixed color-and-label mapping for the five work patterns, used everywhere they're referenced. Nothing here changes live dashboard, RACI, or print-doc code until approved.

Token Lock note (Rule 1): the current locked token set doesn't include a validated 5-color pattern mapping — the colors in use today were never run through an accessibility check and aren't part of the token list. This proposal is exactly the case Rule 1 anticipates: "a genuinely new visual need becomes its own proposal, not a local fix." One deliberate choice inside it — Transaction's gold is a new, distinct hex, *not* a reuse of the locked amber (#B8873F), since Rule 1 reserves that color for draft/pending status only, never decorative use.

Why This Now

GiGi's site review asked for the five work patterns to get "a stronger visual identity... consistent labels, subtle color cues" — right now they read more like a legend than building blocks. Before picking new colors, I ran the current palette through a real colorblind-safety check rather than eyeballing it, using the same validated method the framework's own dataviz work uses. It surfaced something worth seeing before choosing new colors: the current palette doesn't just look plain, it fails.

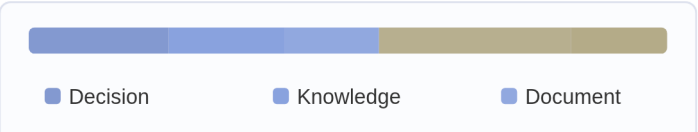
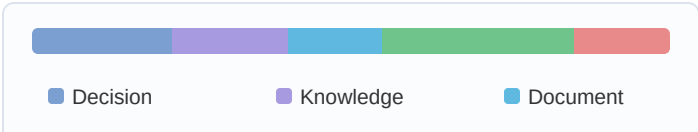
The Problem

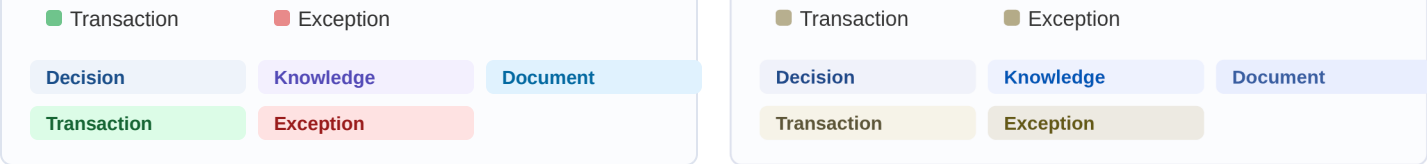
Transaction (green) and Exception (red) are nearly indistinguishable to a reader with red-green colorblindness — roughly 1 in 12 men. Decision (blue) and Knowledge (violet) are too close even for full-color vision. Both failures show up everywhere the pattern-mix bars, badges, and legend appear: Maturity Table, RACI Table, AI Capability Map, Value Stream Profile pages, and the print docs.

Current palette

NORMAL VISION

SIMULATED — DEUTERANOPIA



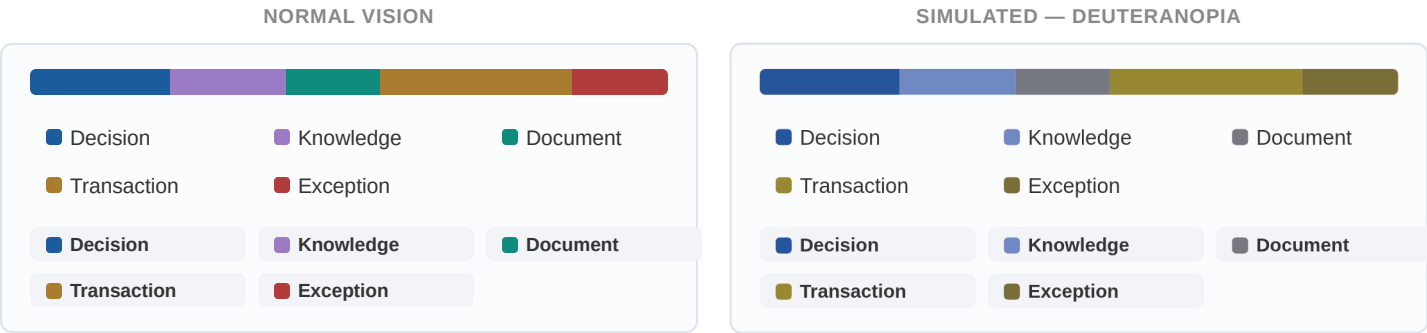


Measured: Transaction vs. Exception at ΔE 1.2 under deuteranopia simulation (essentially identical); Decision vs. Knowledge at ΔE 6.5 even under normal color vision (below the 15-point threshold for "easy to tell apart").

The Recommendation

Two changes together, not one. First, the five hues move: Document shifts from a blue-adjacent cyan to teal, and Transaction shifts from green to gold — the change that actually breaks the red-green collision, not a shade adjustment. Second, badges stop coloring the pattern name itself — a small colored dot carries the identity, the label stays plain dark ink, matching how the legend already works. That second change is what lets the palette stay muted and coordinated with the framework's navy identity without asking any single color to double as both an identity cue and a readable text color.

Recommended palette — dot + plain-ink badges



Validated: worst colorblind-pair ΔE 9.4, worst full-color-vision pair ΔE 15.6 — both clear of the safety floors. No badge, bar, or legend dot relies on hue alone to carry meaning.

Proposed Tokens

PATTERN	HEX	NOTE
Decision	#1A5C9C	Nearly the framework's own locked navy (#1B4F8A) — nudged just enough to separate from Knowledge
Knowledge	#9B7BC4	Dusty violet, softened from the current bright purple
Document	#0F8C7E	Muted teal — moved off blue so it stops crowding Decision
Transaction	#A97C2F	A new gold, related in spirit to the locked amber but a distinct hex — see Token Lock note above
Exception	#B23B3B	Muted brick red, softened from the current alarm-red

Build Note

This is a convention repeated in several places, not one component: the Maturity Table's pattern-mix bars, the RACI Table's pattern column, L4 badges, the legend, the AI Capability Map cards, Value Stream Profile pages, and the docx/PDF print pipeline all currently draw from the same PATTERN_META/PATTERN_HEX constants. A single source-of-truth update there propagates everywhere — but the print docs (docx-js) build their own color logic separately and would need their own pass. Recommend rolling out to the live dashboard first, then porting to the print generators once confirmed.

Tim King & Claude | Concept — For Review | September 2026

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HITL-Driven Architecture · developed with the assistance of Claude (Anthropic)

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